

FEBRUARY

2026

MONTHLY THREAT REPORT

Executive Summary

Welcome to the Misbar threat intelligence assessment for **February 2026**. The month delivered a paradoxical signal: ransomware victim counts held steady at the elevated **~680 monthly baseline** established in January, yet the operator landscape continued its rapid fragmentation as **54 distinct groups** competed for affiliates and victims across an increasingly crowded extortion economy.

Two trends defined the month. First, Qilin held its dominant position with 104 claimed victims, its second consecutive 100+ month, confirming the group's transition from emerging player to entrenched RaaS leader. Second, TheGentlemen, a newcomer that surfaced in late 2025, nearly doubled its January output to **78 victims**, signaling the rise of experienced operators rebranding under fresh banners to evade attribution.

Healthcare suffered disproportionately: incidents more than doubled from January to **93 victims**, second only to manufacturing. The shift coincided with a wider geographic spread, with Brazil and Japan entering the top ten target countries for the first time as ransomware operators continued probing for under-defended digital economies.

The vulnerability story of the month was **CVE-2026-1731**, a critical pre-authentication RCE in BeyondTrust Remote Support and Privileged Remote Access. Disclosed February 6, exploited in the wild by February 10, and added to CISA's KEV catalog by February 13, the flaw saw a working PoC published to GitHub the same day exploitation began, a four-day window from disclosure to mass scanning.

The Misbar Team continues to track these shifts in near real time. This report distills the month's most consequential signals into prioritized intelligence designed to help defenders allocate finite resources against an adversary economy that is growing more diffuse, more opportunistic, and more efficient by the quarter.

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Ransomware Landscape

February 2026 closed with ransomware activity holding flat against January, suggesting the elevated post-2025 attack baseline has stabilized rather than receded. Operators continued shifting toward in-house, agile teams over monolithic RaaS franchises, with a long tail of smaller groups now contributing meaningful volume.

CLAIMED VICTIMS

680

flat vs January

ACTIVE GROUPS

54

across 72 countries

YTD VICTIMS

1,357

Jan–Feb cumulative

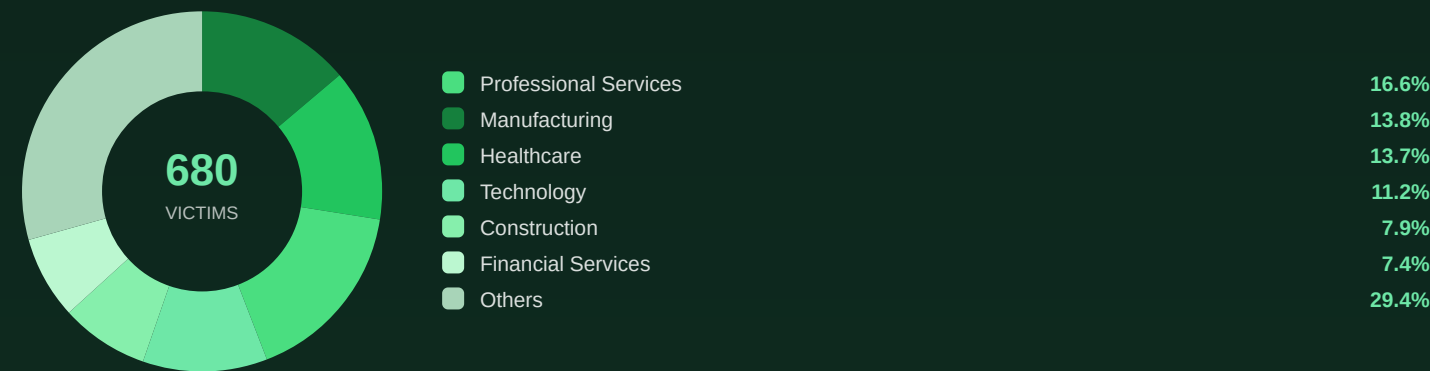
VS 2025 AVG

+12%

monthly average

Sector Distribution

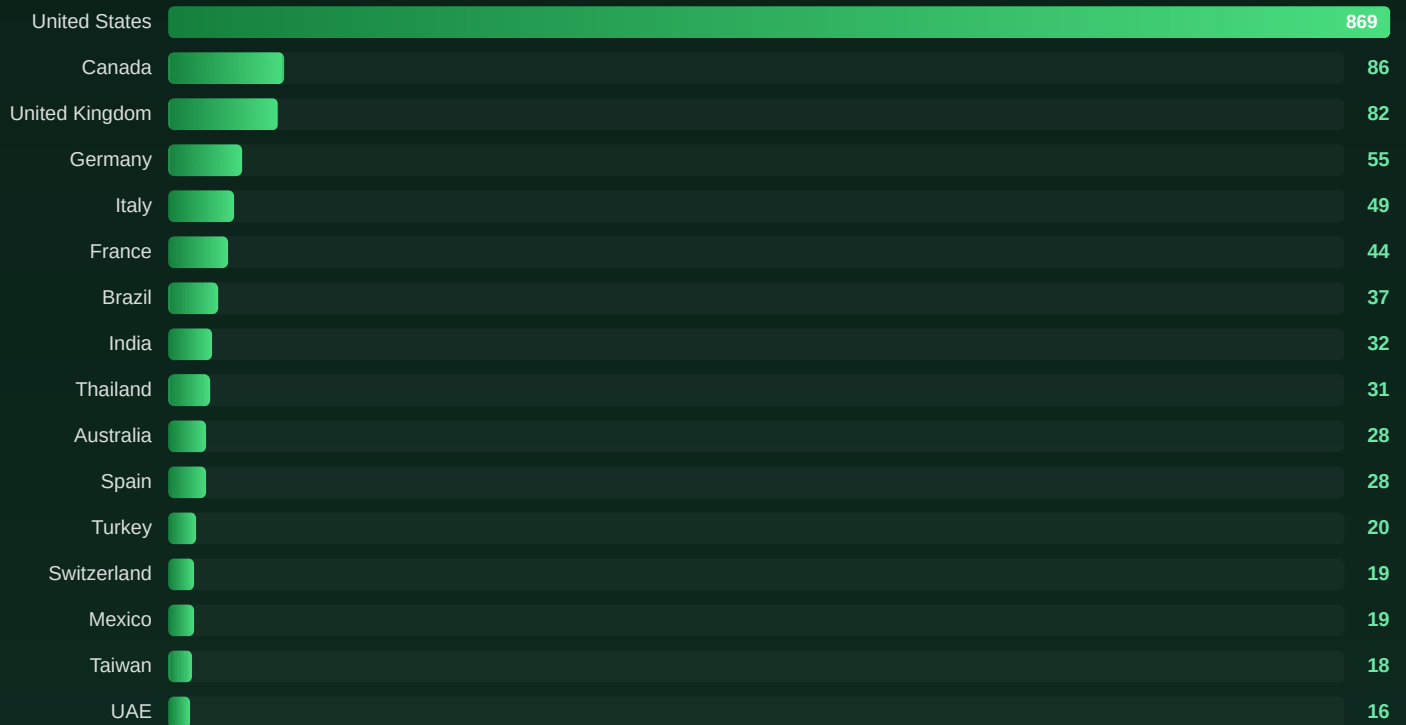
Manufacturing retained its position as the most-targeted sector with **94 victims**, while healthcare surged dramatically, more than doubling January's count to reach **93 victims**. Professional services followed closely at 113 incidents according to alternate trackers, reflecting persistent attacker focus on data-rich, disruption-sensitive industries.



February 2026 ransomware victims by sector

Geographic Distribution

The United States remained the overwhelming target with **869 victims** across the broader tracked universe, while Western European economies held secondary positions. Notably, Brazil and Japan entered the top tier of targeted countries this month, a signal that ransomware operators are systematically expanding into mature regional markets rather than concentrating purely on Anglophone targets.



Geographic distribution of observed ransomware victims, February 2026

Brazil's rise into the top ten is meaningful: it reflects a maturing Latin American digital economy now attractive to RaaS affiliates, who increasingly view the region as under-defended relative to its commercial value. Japan's appearance follows a parallel pattern across Asia-Pacific.

Most Active Ransomware Groups

A small concentration of groups continues to drive the majority of observed ransomware activity, though the long tail is growing. February's top ten accounted for roughly **68.7% of victims**, leaving 44 smaller operators to share the remaining 31%. The headline story remains Qilin's consistency and TheGentlemen's rapid scaling.

#	GROUP	VICTIMS (FEB)	VS JANUARY	PROFILE
01	Qilin	104	-3	RaaS · double extortion · healthcare focus
02	TheGentlemen	78	+37	Emerging RaaS · rapid affiliate growth
03	CL0P	49	-55	Mass exploitation · Oracle EBS campaign tail
04	Akira	39	-32	Established RaaS · SonicWall VPN exploit
05	Play	42	+10	Double extortion · credential-based access
06	DragonForce	30	+4	Extortion-driven · climbing affiliate base
07	Sinobi	18	-37	Emerging actor · sharp February decline

Top ransomware operators ranked by February 2026 victim count

Key Movements

TheGentlemen's surge from 41 to 78 victims is the month's most operationally significant signal. The trajectory pattern, modest debut, rapid scaling, mirrors how experienced ransomware operators rebrand to escape law enforcement attention. Behavioral analysis of the group's TTPs suggests deep affiliate experience rather than novice operations.

CL0P's contraction from 90 to 35 reflects the natural ebb of mass-exploitation campaigns: the group's Oracle E-Business Suite operation continues to produce victim disclosures from late-2025 exfiltration, but new initial-access activity has slowed. **Sinobi's collapse** from 55 to 18 suggests either internal disruption or a deliberate operational pause.

Note on 0APT: Multiple intelligence firms confirmed that the "0APT" group's claim of 183 February victims was fabricated, likely a credibility-building scam to attract affiliates. Misbar excludes this data from all February figures.

Notable Attacks, February

February's incident wave concentrated heavily on hospitality, payments infrastructure, and standards bodies, sectors where attackers calculated that brand sensitivity and operational dependency would accelerate negotiation. Below are the month's most consequential confirmed incidents.

Wynn Resorts

HOSPITALITY · SHINYHUNTERS · FEB 2026

Wynn Resorts confirmed a security incident after ShinyHunters listed the casino chain on its leak site, claiming exfiltration of approximately 800,000 records. Wynn was removed from the leak portal shortly after listing, indicating either rapid negotiation or remediation. The incident is the second major Las Vegas-strip extortion event in 18 months and underscores ongoing weakness in hospitality identity systems.

BridgePay Network Solutions

PAYMENTS · RANSOMWARE · FEB 6, 2026

BridgePay, a major U.S. payment gateway serving thousands of municipal and merchant customers, suffered a ransomware attack on February 6 that knocked APIs, virtual terminals, and hosted payment pages offline. Several city governments forced cash-only operations during the outage. BridgePay confirmed restoration of all infrastructure by February 28; no payment-card data was reported compromised.

Conpet (Romania National Pipeline Operator)

CRITICAL INFRASTRUCTURE · QILIN · FEB 2026

Romania's national crude oil pipeline operator, controlling more than 3,800 km of pipeline supplying domestic refineries, was claimed by Qilin. The group exfiltrated over 1 TB of internal documents, passport-level identity records, and financial data. The attack continued Qilin's pattern of targeting energy and critical-infrastructure operators across Europe and South Korea.

American National Standards Institute (ANSI)

STANDARDS BODY · FORUM LEAK · FEB 22, 2026

Approximately 2.3 TB of ANSI material, including draft standards, internal communications, rejected submissions, technical committee records, and access logs, was posted to a data-breach forum on February 22. The leak represents one of the largest disclosures ever from a standards organization and may have downstream implications for organizations relying on confidential pre-publication standards review.

Substack

PUBLISHING PLATFORM · DATA THEFT · FEB 3, 2026

Substack disclosed unauthorized third-party access to a subset of user metadata. The platform notified subscribers that email addresses, phone numbers, and other limited data were exposed; passwords and payment data were unaffected. An unidentified actor subsequently claimed to possess data on roughly 700,000 users.

CarGurus

AUTOMOTIVE MARKETPLACE · SHINYHUNTERS · FEB 2026

ShinyHunters claimed compromise of CarGurus' platform with 1.7 million records and 12.6 million account fragments, including email addresses, internal corporate records, user UUIDs, and IP addresses. The dataset combines marketplace-specific PII with internal corporate metadata, suggesting deeper application-layer access than a typical credential-stuffing event.

Vulnerability Landscape

February disclosed **4,619 CVEs**, a moderate dip from January's 4,313 baseline once normalized for the shorter month, but still consistent with the elevated 2026 disclosure cadence. Critically, the rate of CISA KEV additions accelerated, indicating that more disclosed vulnerabilities are crossing the line from theoretical to actively exploited.

CVES PUBLISHED

4,619

Feb 2026

HIGH SEVERITY

1,824

CVSS ≥ 7.0

KEV ADDITIONS

28

actively exploited

DAILY AVERAGE

165

CVEs / day

Top Affected Vendors, February

Microsoft and Apple dominated February disclosures, reflecting both the breadth of their ecosystems and the intense researcher and adversary attention they attract. QNAP and Adobe also recorded substantial counts, driven by ongoing scrutiny of network-attached storage and creative software respectively.

Microsoft		258
Apple		139
Linux		124
Google		91
QNAP		78
Adobe		62
Oracle		57
Tenda		54
IBM		47
D-Link		41

Top vendors by published vulnerability count, February 2026

Spotlight: BeyondTrust RCE (CVE-2026-1731)

The vulnerability of February 2026 was **CVE-2026-1731**, a critical pre-authentication remote code execution flaw in BeyondTrust Remote Support (RS) and Privileged Remote Access (PRA). The bug carried a CVSSv4 score of **9.9** and was exploited within **96 hours** of public disclosure. The combination of attack surface, simplicity, and target footprint, BeyondTrust serves more than 20,000 customers including 75% of the Fortune 100, made this the highest-stakes patching event of Q1.

CVE-2026-1731, Technical Snapshot

CWE: CWE-78 (OS Command Injection)

CVSSv4: 9.9 / 10 (Critical)

Vector: Network · Pre-Auth · No User Interaction

Affected: RS ≤ 25.3.1 · PRA ≤ 24.3.4

Fixed in: RS 25.3.2 · PRA 25.1.1

Endpoint: thin-scc-wrapper WebSocket handler

Trigger: Crafted remoteVersion field in WebSocket message

Disclosure-to-Exploit Timeline

The compressed timeline between disclosure and active exploitation demonstrates how thoroughly the modern attack economy is now optimized around new vulnerability research. BeyondTrust patched its SaaS customers automatically on February 2; the public CVE landed February 6; the first PoC appeared on GitHub February 10; mass scanning began the same day; and CISA added the CVE to KEV by February 13.

DATE	EVENT
Jan 31, 2026	Hacktron AI discovers via AI-enabled variant analysis; ~11,000 instances exposed, 8,500 on-prem
Feb 02, 2026	BeyondTrust automatically patches all SaaS customers
Feb 06, 2026	Advisory BT26-02 and CVE-2026-1731 published
Feb 09, 2026	Rapid7, Canadian Cyber Centre publish detection guidance
Feb 10, 2026	Public PoC released on GitHub; first exploitation observed in the wild
Feb 11, 2026	GreyNoise records mass scanning; single Frankfurt VPN IP responsible for 86% of probes
Feb 13, 2026	CISA adds CVE-2026-1731 to KEV catalog · Unit 42 reports broad exploitation

Exploitation Mechanics & Post-Exploit Behavior

The exploit itself is trivially simple: a single WebSocket message with a manipulated **remoteVersion** string reaching the **thin-scc-wrapper** component executes attacker-supplied OS commands as the site user. The vulnerability is a variant of **CVE-2024-12356**, which Chinese state actor Silk Typhoon used to breach the U.S. Treasury in late 2024. Same WebSocket endpoint, different code path, the December 2024 patch did *not* cover this variant.

Post-compromise behavior included dropping renamed SimpleHelp RMM binaries to **C:\ProgramData**, adding domain accounts to Enterprise Admins via **net group**, LDAP enumeration with AdsISearcher, and lateral movement via PSEXEC and Impacket SMBv2 sessions. By late February, suspected actors were chaining the bug into LockBit deployments.

Defender Takeaway: Self-hosted BeyondTrust customers without auto-update enabled who delayed patching past February 11 should assume potential compromise and conduct full incident-response forensics. The vulnerability sits on a management plane, once root is achieved, attackers inherit the credentials and network topology that the platform was built to manage.

Recent Known Exploited Vulnerabilities

The following entries were added to CISA's Known Exploited Vulnerabilities catalog during February 2026. KEV listings reflect confirmed exploitation in the wild, not theoretical severity, making them the highest-priority remediation targets for any vulnerability management program.

CVE ID	VENDOR / PRODUCT	DATE ADDED	DUE DATE	NOTES
CVE-2026-1731	BeyondTrust RS / PRA	2/13/2026	3/06/2026	Pre-auth RCE · CVSS 9.9
CVE-2026-43528	Apple, iOS / macOS	2/13/2026	3/06/2026	Memory corruption · targeted
CVE-2025-14174	Apple, Multiple Products	2/13/2026	3/06/2026	Sophisticated targeted attack
CVE-2025-43529	Apple, Multiple Products	2/13/2026	3/06/2026	Linked to iOS pre-26 exploitation
CVE-2025-26399	SolarWinds Web Help Desk	2/12/2026	3/05/2026	Auth bypass · public exploit
CVE-2025-68645	Synacor Zimbra Collaboration	2/05/2026	2/26/2026	PHP RFI · unauthenticated
CVE-2025-34026	Versa Concerto SD-WAN	2/05/2026	2/26/2026	Auth bypass · CVSS 9.2
CVE-2025-31125	Vite (vitejs)	2/05/2026	2/26/2026	Improper access control
CVE-2026-21385	Qualcomm Android Component	2/14/2026	3/07/2026	Buffer over-read · in-the-wild
CVE-2025-67890	Notepad++ WinGUp Updater	2/19/2026	3/12/2026	Update integrity bypass
CVE-2025-37164	HPE OneView	2/03/2026	2/24/2026	Code injection

Selected KEV catalog additions during February 2026 (compiled from CISA disclosures)

Apple cluster: The simultaneous February 13 addition of CVE-2025-14174, CVE-2025-43529, and CVE-2026-43528 reflects a single sophisticated campaign targeting specific individuals on iOS versions earlier than 26. Mobile fleet patching cadence remains a high-value control even when enterprise endpoints dominate program attention.

Conclusion

February 2026 confirmed that the post-2025 ransomware baseline is now structural rather than transient. Volume held flat at the elevated **~680 monthly** level while the operator population continued to fragment, a configuration that historically precedes either rapid consolidation around new dominant platforms or sustained chaos as smaller groups compete for affiliate share.

Healthcare's sharp resurgence and the geographic broadening into Brazil and Japan suggest opportunistic targeting is intensifying. Defenders in those regions and sectors should expect probing activity to convert into incidents over the coming quarter. Manufacturing remains the perennial top target, a dynamic unlikely to change while operational disruption continues to drive ransom payments.

The vulnerability story of the month, **CVE-2026-1731**, will cast a long shadow. The four-day window between disclosure and mass exploitation is now the realistic planning assumption for any pre-auth RCE in a privileged-access platform. Programs that treat patch cycles as monthly or quarterly should formally exempt KEV-listed flaws and route them through emergency-change processes.

Recommended Actions

- 1. BeyondTrust forensics now.** Self-hosted Remote Support and PRA customers without auto-update should assume compromise if patching slipped past February 11. Hunt for renamed SimpleHelp binaries in **C:\ProgramData**, unauthorized Domain Admin additions, and **bomgar-scc.exe** -spawned suspicious children.
- 2. Credential hygiene first.** Most ransomware in 2026 still begins with infostealer-harvested credentials, not zero-days. Continuous monitoring of dark-web credential exposure remains the single highest-leverage defensive control.
- 3. KEV-first patching.** Treat any CVE entering CISA's KEV as a same-week patching obligation regardless of vendor cycle. Build automation around KEV ingestion rather than manual review.
- 4. Healthcare and manufacturing, rehearse recovery.** Sectors with the highest victim concentration must move beyond prevention into validated recovery: immutable backups, tested restoration, and documented downtime playbooks.
- 5. Watch TheGentlemen and similar emerging operators.** Behavioral indicators trump brand attribution in 2026, track tradecraft (SystemBC, Mimikatz patterns, Group Policy abuse) rather than chasing rebrands.

The Misbar Team will continue tracking these developments in real time. February's signals, fragmentation, geographic expansion, healthcare resurgence, and the BeyondTrust mass-exploitation event, should be treated as indicators of where Q2 is likely to intensify rather than as one-off observations.

END OF REPORT, FEBRUARY 2026